

Alternative Time is an exploration of how time is produced—not as a singular flow, but through repeated encounters between systems, environments, and people. It begins with a simple distinction: the time we follow is shared, but the time we live emerges through events.

Standardized time systems such as UTC, and their local adaptations like IST, enable synchronization. They structure collective life through uniform intervals, allowing people and infrastructures to operate together. Yet this shared time often conceals the unevenness of lived experience. Across India, a single time zone spans multiple geographies, where daylight, climate, and daily rhythms do not align uniformly. What is shared is not always what is experienced.

Alongside this exists event time—time that does not unfold evenly, but accumulates through presence, repetition, and interaction. It is not counted in seconds, but formed through encounters.

This work brings these temporalities into a single system, where time is not displayed but gradually constructed.

At its center is a 25×36 LED grid that functions as a shared visual field. The grid captures a live image of the person standing before it, but this image does not appear instantly. Instead, it emerges incrementally, shaped by sustained presence. An encounter is not triggered by mere detection, but by duration—by remaining within the system long enough for it to register and respond. During each encounter, fragments of the image intensify from a dim state to clarity, while others remain suspended at partial visibility. The image is always present, but never fully accessible at once.

Each encounter contributes to this gradual reconstruction. It takes **seven encounters** for the grid to reach a state of full visibility, yet this completion is neither immediate nor stable. The system resists quick resolution; it requires return, attention, and continuity. If presence is brief or unstable, the image remains incomplete, introducing the possibility that time, once interrupted, does not fully accumulate.

Running alongside the grid is a system of rotating discs that act as a temporal engine. These discs continuously attempt to synchronize, aligning into a coherent pattern only at specific moments—on the first encounter, and again on the seventh. At all other times, they remain slightly out of phase, rotating in near alignment but never fully converging. This persistent misalignment reflects the condition of shared time: a structure that aspires to uniformity, yet remains offset by the variability of lived experience.

The state of these discs directly influences the behavior of the grid. When alignment is distant, the image appears diffused and unstable, resisting clarity. As the discs approach synchrony, portions of the grid momentarily sharpen, allowing fragments of the image to resolve. When alignment is achieved, the system briefly stabilizes, producing a coherent visual state before drifting again. In this way, synchronization is not a constant condition, but a fleeting event.

The installation also retains traces of past encounters. During each interaction, it extracts and stores the color palette of the participant's presence. Over time, these palettes accumulate as a memory of previous states. When the same individual returns after a cycle of seven days, their live image is re-rendered through this stored palette, merging present input with past traces. The image becomes a composite—part immediate, part remembered—revealing how time carries forward and reshapes perception.

Encounters are recognized through facial identification, allowing the system to track continuity across visits. However, the system does not simply count appearances; it registers the quality and duration of presence, making time contingent on engagement rather than occurrence.

The seventh encounter does not function as a final reward, but as a threshold. At this point, the system reaches a moment of maximum coherence—where the grid fully resolves and the discs align—but this state is temporary. Almost immediately, the system begins to destabilize again, preventing time from settling into a fixed or completed form. Completion gives way to drift, and clarity returns to fragmentation.

Alternative Time does not present time as something that can be read at a glance. Instead, it unfolds through sustained engagement and return. Shared time continues to operate in the background—structured, consistent, and indifferent—while event time builds gradually through presence, interaction, and memory.

By placing these temporalities within a single perceptual field, the work proposes a shift in how time is understood. It is no longer a fixed metric to be observed, but a condition that is continuously produced—through repetition, misalignment, and the accumulation of encounters that shape what can be seen and when.



